

Thea Wachtler

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Education

- Pitzer College** Aug. 2026–Present
- B.A., Political Science in 2029. GPA: 4.00.
- Willamette University** Aug. 2025–May 2026
- Elected to the Associated Students of W.U. Senate
- Damien High School** Aug. 2021–May 2025
- Valedictorian, Junior of the Year, AP Scholar with Distinction, and NMSC commended student. GPA: 4.55 (3.98 u.).
 - Certificates of outstanding achievement in 18 classes.
 - Participated in the Project Lead the Way Engineering and Computer Science programs.

Extracurriculars

- British Parliamentary Debate** Aug. 2025–Present
- Debate Union Treasurer; Managed a \$3,000 budget and coordinated expenditures across registration, travel, and other forensic events.
 - Competed in local and national circuits, accumulating multiple finals placements and speaker awards.
- Policy Debate** Aug. 2021–Apr. 2025
- Varsity letter and team captain; Constructed numerous research-based defenses of policy and critical propositions.
 - Competed on the national circuit with numerous deep tournament runs and qualified to the Tournament of Champions twice.
- Model United Nations Club** Aug. 2025–April 2026
- Treasurer; Organized the hosting of multiple conferences.
- Mock Trial** Sep. 2023–Dec. 2024
- Team captain, club Vice President, lead pre-trial attorney, and primary student organizer.
- Scouting America** Jul. 2018–May 2025
- Troop 403; Eagle Scout (Board of Review pending).
 - Project consisted of significant landscaping, woodworking, and repair efforts at a children’s center over 130 hours.
 - Led classes for youth aged 11–17 in domestic and national politics, fitness, communication, environmental science, and metalworking.
- Robotics** Aug. 2024–Jan. 2025
- Lead coder for national-circuit VEX V5 competition.
- Christian Leadership** Aug. 2024–May 2025
- Led religious retreats for peers with a strong emphasis on community-building and spiritual growth.
- Dungeons and Dragons Club** Oct. 2021–April 2026
- President in H.S. and Treasurer in college.
- Ultimate Frisbee Club** Oct. 2023–Oct. 2024
- Secretary; Managed communication and statistics.
- Stagecraft** Jan. 2026–April 2026
- Road Cycling Club** Aug. 2021–Dec. 2022

Summary

Interdisciplinary student and researcher actively engaged in competitive academic discourse, data-driven technical and policy research, and community service.

Research & Programs

- Computing Research Association** Feb. 2026–Jul. 2026
- Contracted researcher in the CRA UR2PhD REU program.
 - Explored the application of machine learning algorithms to the opioid epidemic and built analytical skills.
 - Used a spatio-temporal perspective to classify overdose risk rates based on California SDoH data.
- LEGO Robotics STEM Program** Jan. 2026–May 2026
- Taught Lego Robotics to 1st grade students at Title I elementary schools through a service-learning course.
 - Guided students to follow instructions while consistently reinforcing creativity and problem-solving skills to assure success in alignment with state learning goals.
- Univ. of Michigan Debate Institute** ... Jun. 2023–Jul. 2023
- Studied fiscal redistribution and solutions to income inequality with targeted research on the expansion of SSI to U.S. territories and a FJG in the executive branch.
- Gonzaga Univ. Debate Institute** Jun. 2022–Jul. 2022
- Analyzed U.S.-NATO security cooperation over emerging technologies, specifically regarding integrating machine learning in military and scientific technology and combatting disinformation with cybersecurity techniques.

Project Examples

- QEMU RISC-V Operating System** Jan. 2026–May 2026
- Built a bare-metal O.S. in C for RISC-V architecture with dynamic memory allocation, error handling with run-time symbol resolution, and an interactive Snake game.
- Brick Classifier Prototype** Aug. 2024–May 2025
- Designed and prototyped an automated LEGO sorter machine with a Java host communicating over SSH with an RPI, a VEX V5 brain, an ESP32-CAM, and a gRPC server for real-time classification and motor movement.

Skills

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| Languages | Java, C#, Rust, C, C++, LaTeX, Python |
| Software | Git, Vim, Unity, CMake, Fusion360, LVGL |
| Platforms | Windows, Linux (Arch), MS Office, Google Workspace, Raspberry Pi |
| Engineering | CAD modeling, technical drawing, embedded systems, 3D printing |
| Applied | Landscaping, woodworking, construction, maintenance work |